



HOW THEY STACK UP

New York City's night-time economy supported nearly 299,000 jobs, and \$35.1 billion in economic output in 2016, according to the Mayor's Office of Media and Entertainment



Sydney's night-time economy generates more than \$3.64 billion in tax revenue each year, and employs more than 32,000 people, according to the city's administration



London's night-time economy contributes £26.6 billion to the UK's GDP annually, and employs around 1.6 million people according to a report by the UK's Night Time Industries Association

SOURCE: REPORTS

time economy. He had said that a 24x7 city will not happen overnight, and it has to be achieved through an incremental process.

THE CHALLENGES of creating a night-time economy are enormous. "There are a lot of factors that need to be considered before forming a night-time policy. Basic things can be considered such as concessions on electricity rates, flexibility in labour laws and working hours, and empowering other sectors to work through the night," says Naik of Nexus Malls.

According to Khubani's Madan, security and infrastructure play vital roles in the growth of a night-time economy. "In a city like Delhi, we have very patchy infrastructure at night, no metro or public transport, etc. However, in top night-time economies, infrastructure and public transport along with security add

hugely to the ecosystem. In India, a lot needs to be done from the perspective of night-time economies," he says. He adds that one reason for Delhi's night-time economy being at a nascent stage is because the Delhi Metro operates only till 12 am, and cabs are not readily available throughout the city.

While the challenges of establishing a safe and thriving night-time economy are many, the opportunity it presents is also massive. "If we want the night-time economy to grow, we need to have uniform regulations. This ecosystem has the potential to add to growth, but it's not like it will add a per cent of growth to India's GDP. However, it can add 5-10 per cent into this industry. It will lead to job creation," says Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist of Bank of Baroda.

According to economists, the top 10 cities contribute about \$500 billion to India's \$3-trillion gross domestic product (GDP). If we assume that the night-time economy will add even 6 per cent to the urban output, it amounts to \$30 billion. That is the quantum of growth the Indian economy is expected to accrue with a flourishing night-time economy.

"I think with security, and a robust infrastructure in the city, it will lead to a manifold jump in our revenues. If we get the government's support in terms of policy, like businesses are getting in western countries, I am sure, what business we are doing throughout the day, we will do that business in 4-5 hours at night," says Khubani's Madan on the potential of the night-time economy in Delhi.

Batra of Cafe Delhi Heights opines that it's not only food and drinks that make a night-time economy functional. "We should have grocery stores, malls, and a mix of entertainment to create a 360-degree night market. Why can't I have a haircut at midnight? Why can't I go to study in a library at midnight? We should have all the options," he says.

Those options, of course, are a little way away. As they say, the night is young, and full of expectations. **BT**

@RajatMishra9518